THE PIANO BUTLER · LEVEL BOOK

Grade 1

One step on each page: a big picture, a few words, and one thing to try at the piano. The last room trains your ears.

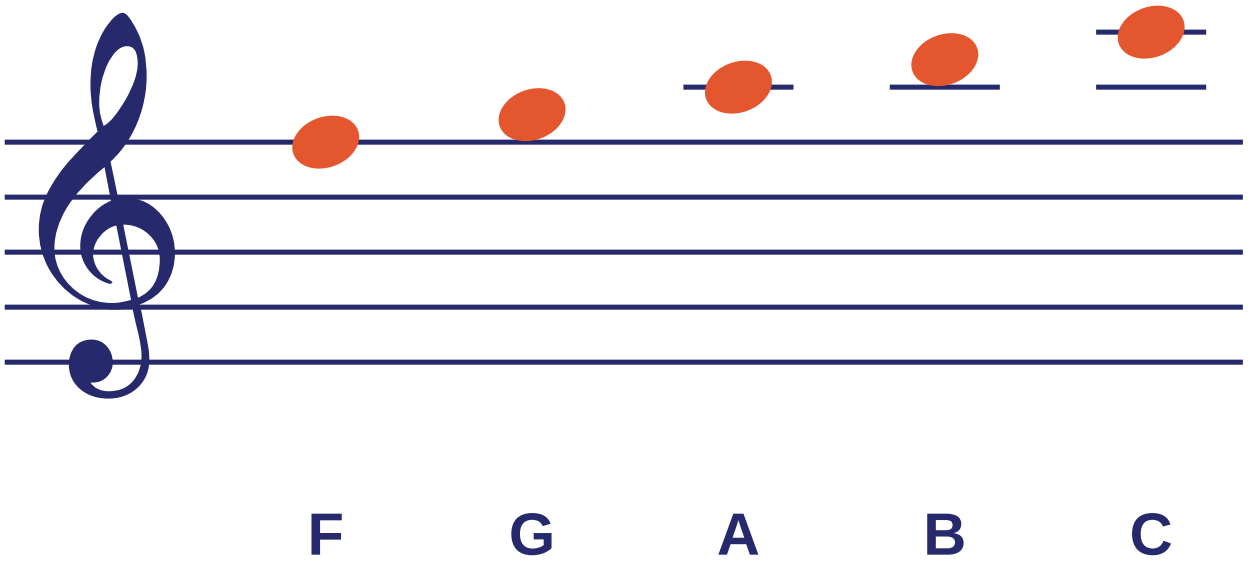
THE ROOMS

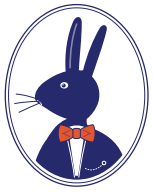
1 · Ledger lines
2 · Sharps, flats and naturals
3 · Counting intervals
4 · Keys and key signatures
5 · Six-eight time
6 · Speed words
7 · Major and minor triads
8 · Reading at sight
9 · Ear training

ROOM 1 · STEP 1 OF 2

Ledger lines

SCAN TO LISTEN





When notes climb above the staff, they get short lines of their own: **ledger lines**.

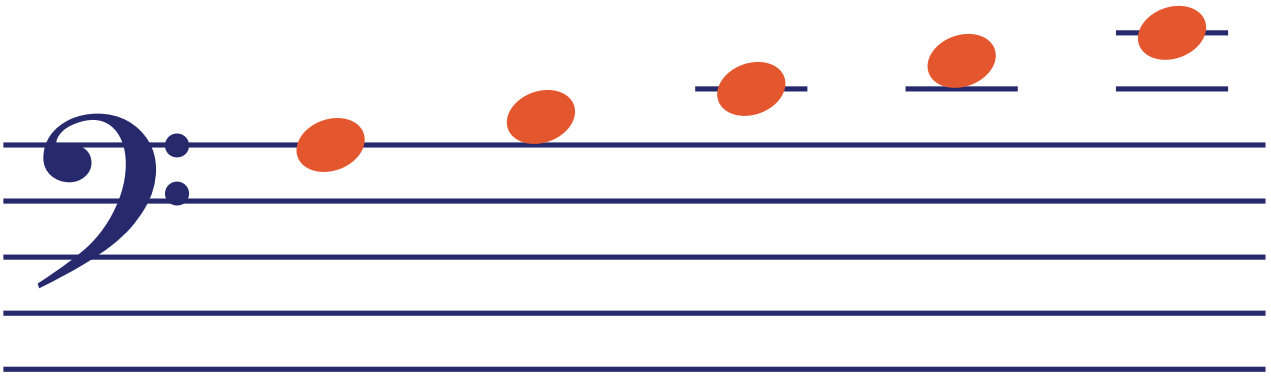
Lines and spaces still take turns. Above the top line F comes G in the space, then **A** on the first ledger line.

Try it at the piano

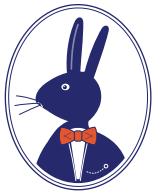
1. Play F G A B C going up from the top line of the treble staff. Say “line, space, line, space, line”.

ROOM 1 · STEP 2 OF 2

Ledger lines



A B C D E



Middle C sits on one ledger line above the bass staff. It is the same key as the C on one ledger line below the treble staff.

So the left hand can climb past Middle C: C, D, E.

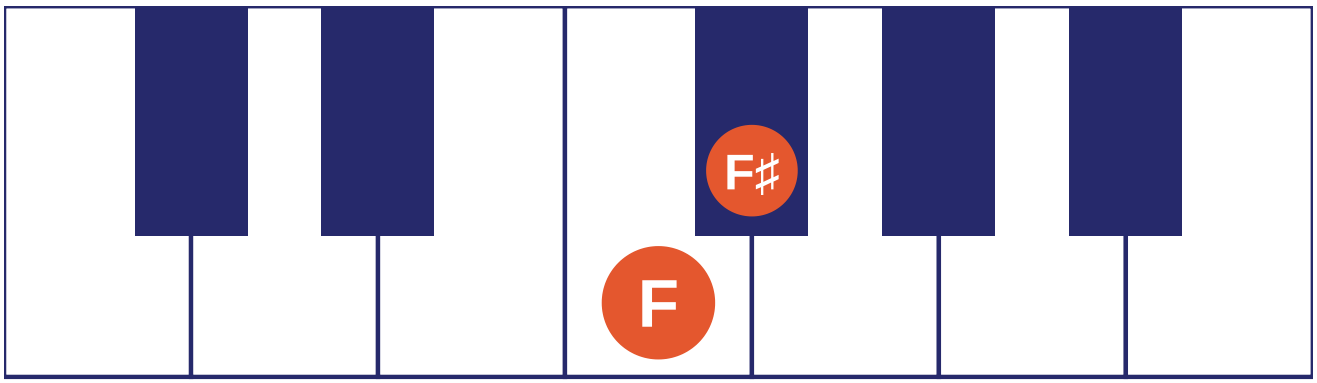
Try it at the piano

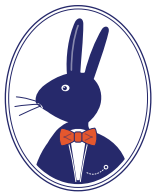
1 With your left hand play A B C D E going up. The C in the middle is Middle C.

ROOM 2 · STEP 1 OF 3

Sharps, flats and naturals

SCAN TO LISTEN





A **sharp** (♯) raises a note to the **very next key on the right**.

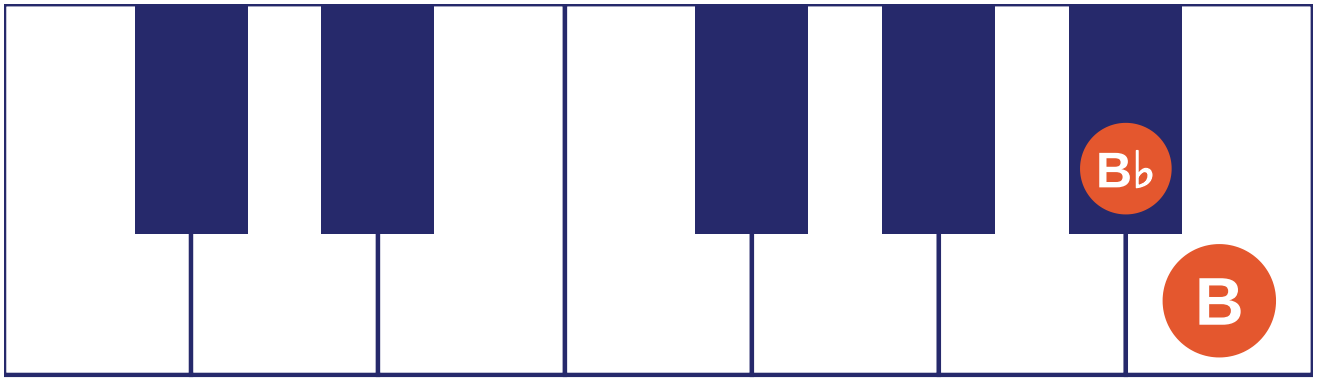
F sharp is the black key just to the right of F.

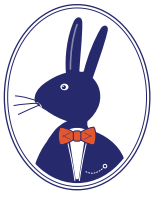
Try it at the piano

1 Play F, then F sharp. Then find C sharp and G sharp the same way.

ROOM 2 · STEP 2 OF 3

Sharps, flats and naturals





A **flat** (♭) lowers a note to the **very next key on the left**.

B flat is the black key just to the left of B.

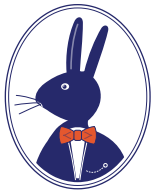
Try it at the piano

1 Play B, then B flat. Then find E flat and A flat the same way.

ROOM 2 · STEP 3 OF 3

Sharps, flats and naturals

♯	♭	♮
sharp	**flat**	**natural**
one key to the right	one key to the left	back to the white key



A sharp or a flat written beside a note lasts until the **end of the bar**. A **natural** (♮) cancels it and sends the note back to its white key.

The sign is written before the note, but we say it after: “F sharp”.

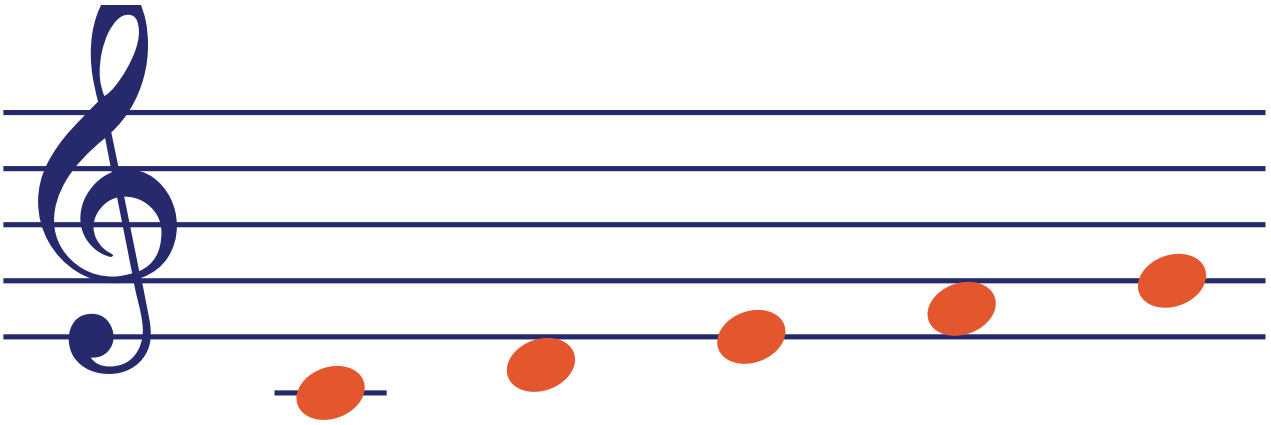
Try it at the piano

1 Play F sharp, then F natural. Play B flat, then B natural.

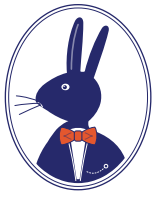
ROOM 3 · STEP 1 OF 2

Counting intervals

SCAN TO LISTEN



C · 1 D · 2 E · 3 F · 4 G · 5



An **interval** is the distance between two notes. Count the letter names, **both ends included**.

From C up to G is C, D, E, F, G: five notes. That is a **5th**.

Try it at the piano

1 Play C and G together with fingers 1 and 5. You are playing a 5th.

ROOM 3 · STEP 2 OF 2

Counting intervals

2nd

a step

line to space, or space to line

3rd

a skip

line to line, or space to space

4th

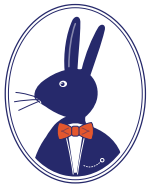
a skip and a step

line to space, missing one

5th

two skips

line, miss a line, line



You can see an interval before you count it. A **2nd** goes from a line to the next space. A **3rd** goes from a line to the next line, or space to space.

A **4th** is a skip and a step. A **5th** skips twice: line, miss a line, line.

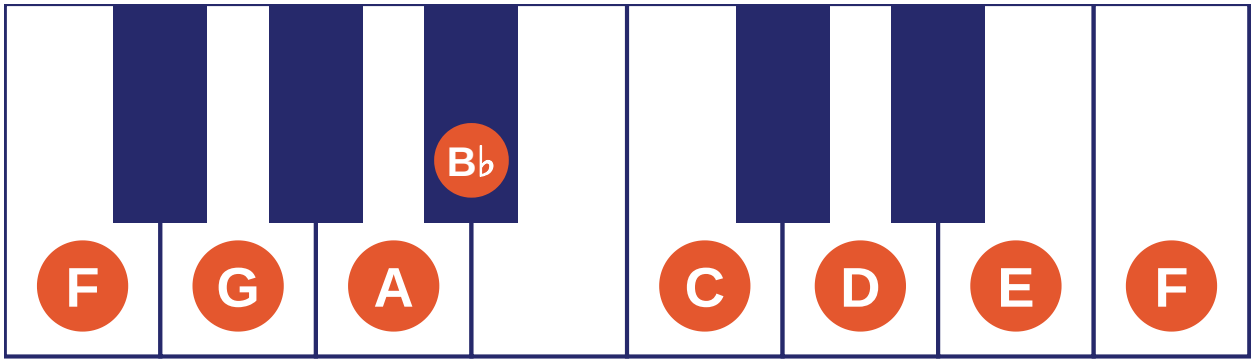
Try it at the piano

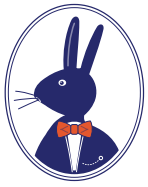
1 Play C–D (a 2nd), C–E (a 3rd), C–F (a 4th) and C–G (a 5th). Listen to how each one sounds.

ROOM 4 · STEP 1 OF 4

Keys and key signatures

SCAN TO LISTEN





F major starts the scale ladder on F. The 4th note has to change: B becomes **B flat**, so that notes 3 and 4 stay close together, with no key between.
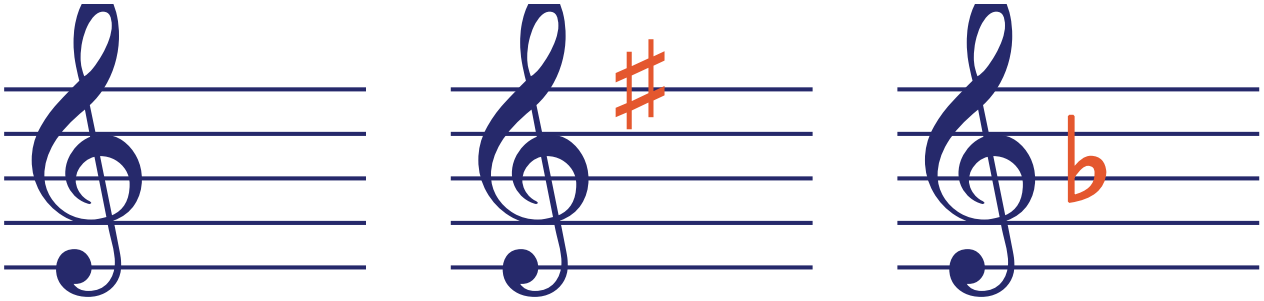
F major has one flat, B♭.

Try it at the piano

1 Play F G A, then the black key B flat, then C D E F. Right hand fingers: 1 2 3 4 (finger 4 on B flat), then the thumb goes under: 1 2 3 4.

ROOM 4 · STEP 2 OF 4

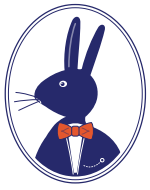
Keys and key signatures



C major
nothing

G major
one sharp: F♯

F major
one flat: B♭



The **key signature** after the clef tells you the key. Nothing: C major. One sharp: G major. **One flat**, on the B line: F major.

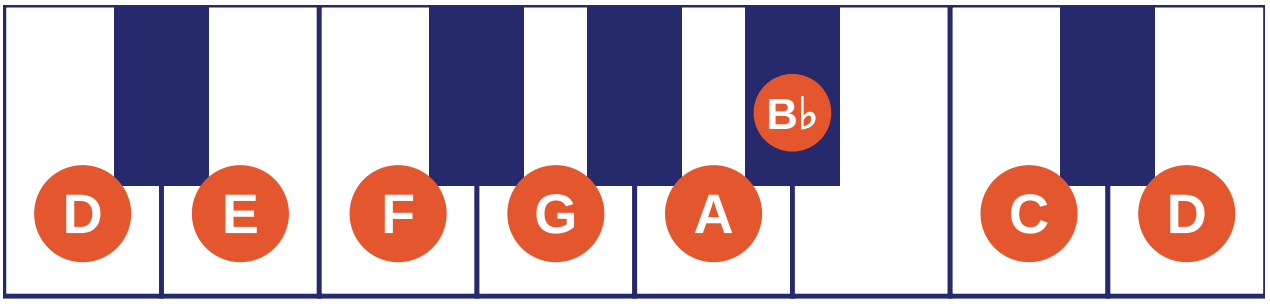
A flat in the key signature lasts for the whole piece: every B is played as B flat.

Try it at the piano

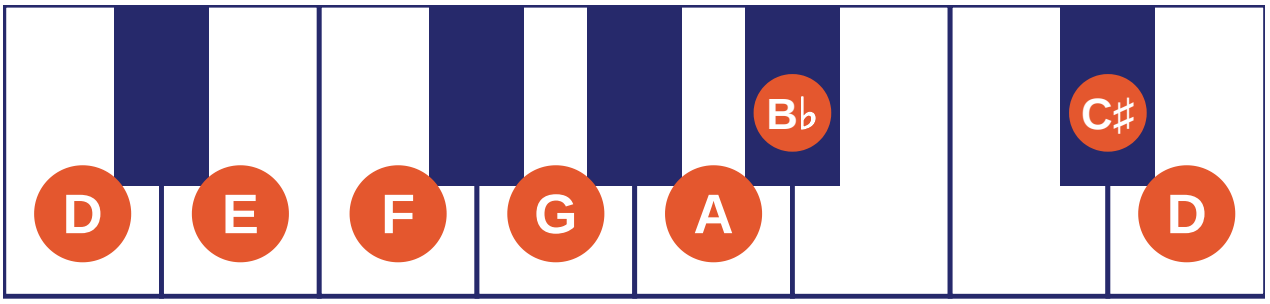
1 Look at the start of your piece. Sharps, flats or nothing? Which major key has this key signature?

ROOM 4 · STEP 3 OF 4

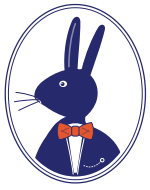
Keys and key signatures



D natural minor



D harmonic minor



D minor uses the same notes as F major, so it keeps **B flat** and the same key signature. D is home.

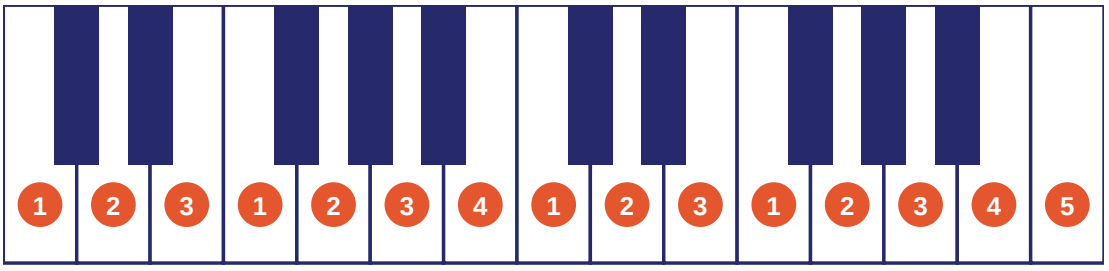
For the harmonic minor, raise the 7th note by one key: C becomes **C sharp**.

Try it at the piano

1. Play D natural minor (with B flat), then D harmonic minor (B flat and C sharp).

ROOM 4 · STEP 4 OF 4

Keys and key signatures





Now your scales grow to **two octaves**. At the top of the first octave, do not stop: the **thumb tucks under** again and the pattern starts over. This picture is C major, right hand.

Going up: 1 2 3, 1 2 3 4, 1 2 3, 1 2 3 4 5. Coming down: 5 4 3 2 1, 3 2 1, 4 3 2 1, 3 2 1. Finger 3 crosses over, then finger 4. The left hand uses the same numbers the other way round. D minor uses these fingers too; F major has its own (see step 1).

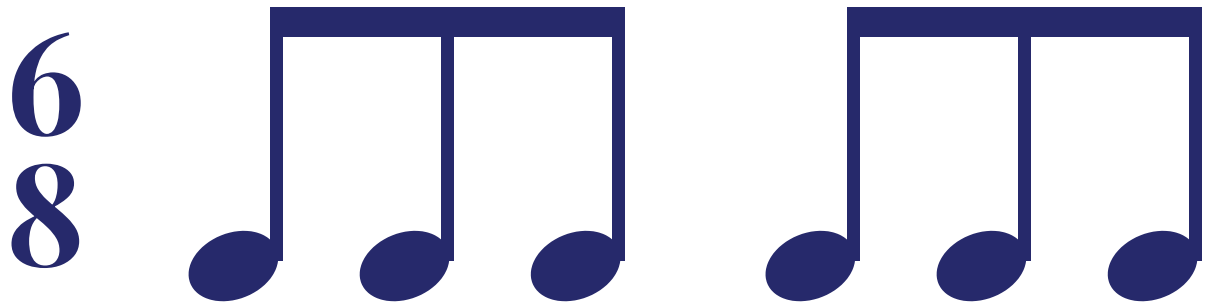
Try it at the piano

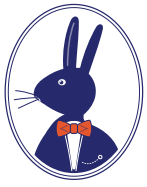
1. Play C major, then D minor, right hand, two octaves up and down, slowly. Keep the beat steady as the thumb passes under.

ROOM 5 · STEP 1 OF 2

Six-eight time

SCAN TO LISTEN





In **six-eight** time a bar holds **six quavers**. They come in **two groups of three**, each joined by a beam.

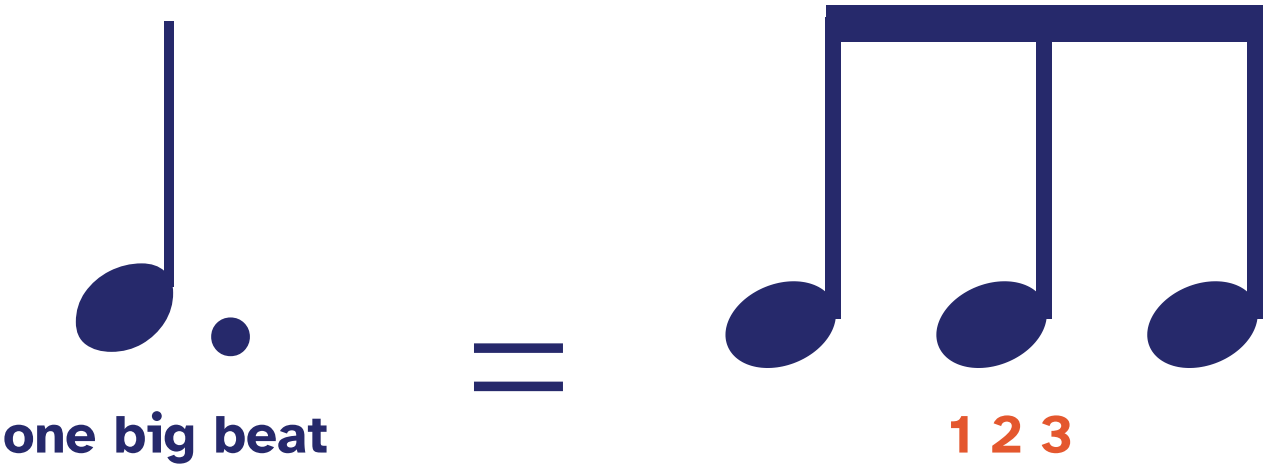
The 6 says six in a bar. The 8 says they are quavers. Count 1 2 3 4 5 6, with 1 and 4 a little stronger.

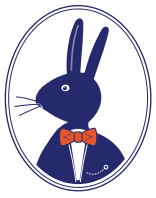
Try it

1. Clap six quavers in a bar: ONE two three FOUR five six. Feel it rock like a boat.

ROOM 5 · STEP 2 OF 2

Six-eight time





Three quavers add up to one **dotted crotchet**. So six-eight has **two big beats** in a bar, and each one splits into three.

Two-four splits each beat in two. Six-eight splits it in three.

Try it

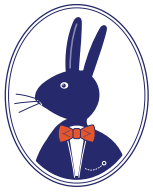
1. Tap two big beats with your left hand. With your right, tap three quavers on each one.

ROOM 6 · STEP 1 OF 2

Speed words

SCAN TO LISTEN

1 **Adagio** slow	2 **Andante** at a walk	3 **Moderato** medium
4 **Allegretto** fairly quick	5 **Allegro** quick and lively	



The word at the very start, above the staff, sets the speed. From slow to quick: **Adagio**, **Andante**, **Moderato**, **Allegretto**, **Allegro**.

Allegretto is a little slower than Allegro.

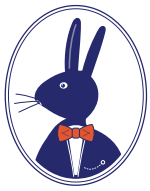
Try it

1 Clap four beats at each speed, from Adagio to Allegro. Then find the speed word in your piece.

ROOM 6 · STEP 2 OF 2

Speed words

rit.	accel.	a tempo
ritardando getting slower	**accelerando** getting quicker	**back to the first speed**



The speed can change on the way. **Ritardando** (rit.) means slow down little by little. **Accelerando** (accel.) means speed up.

A tempo means go back to the speed you had before.

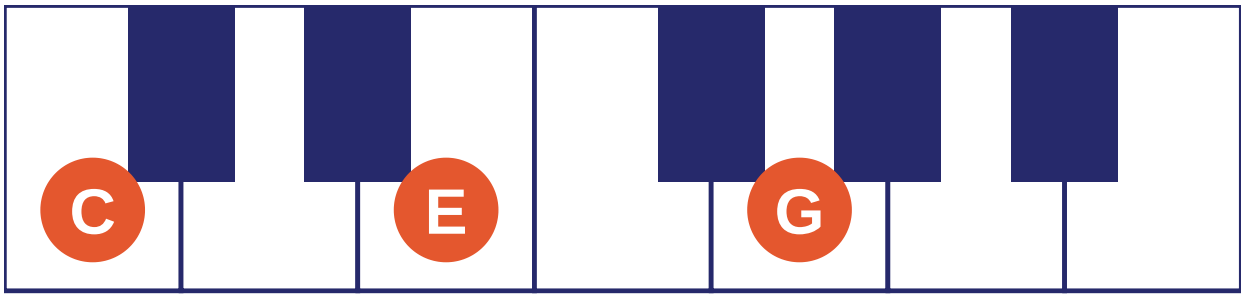
Try it at the piano

1. Play C D E F G getting slower, like a train coming into a station. Then start again a tempo: straight back at your first speed. Then try it getting quicker.

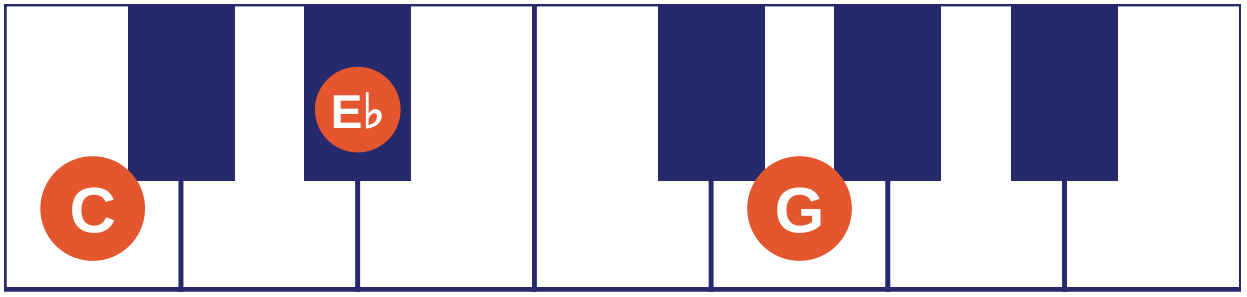
ROOM 7 · STEP 1 OF 2

Major and minor triads

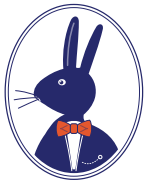
SCAN TO LISTEN



C major



C minor



A **major** triad sounds bright. Lower its **middle note** by one key and it becomes **minor**, which sounds darker.

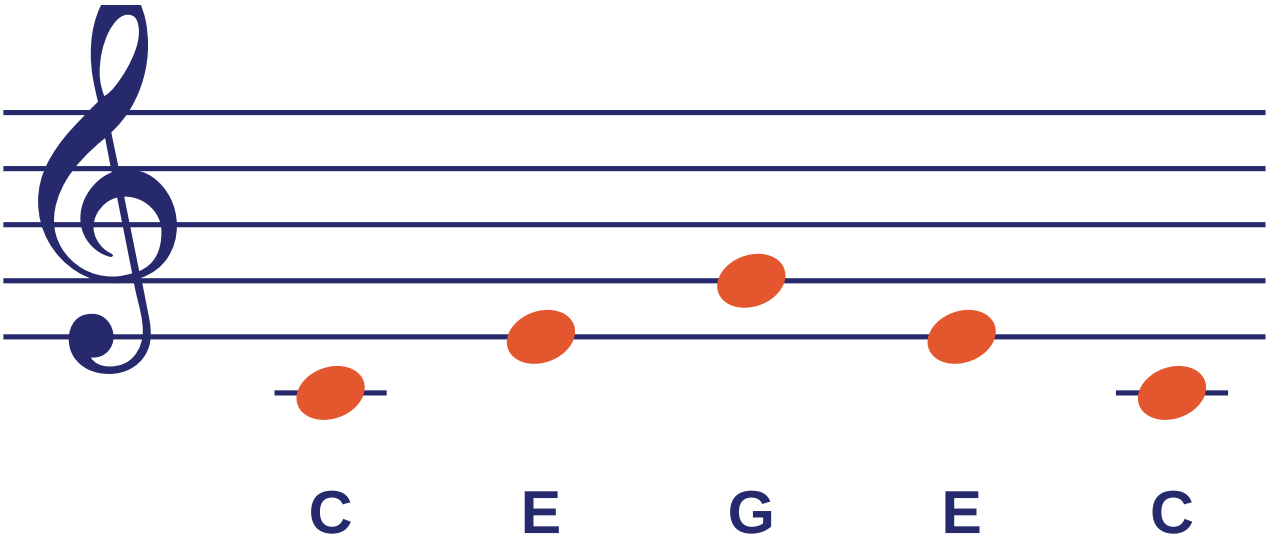
C E G is C major. C E♭ G is C minor. The outside notes stay the same.

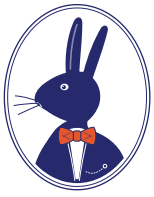
Try it at the piano

1. Play C E G, then C E flat G. Go back and forth and listen to the middle note change the mood.

ROOM 7 · STEP 2 OF 2

Major and minor triads





Play the notes of a triad one after another and you have a **broken triad**.

Up and back: bottom, middle, top, middle, bottom. Many tunes are made of broken triads.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C E G E C with fingers 1 3 5 3 1. Then F A C (major) and D F A (minor), the triads of your new keys.

ROOM 8 · STEP 1 OF 2

Reading at sight

SCAN TO LISTEN

1

Key

sharps, flats or nothing?

2

Time

how many beats?

3

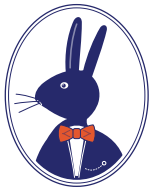
Start

first note, which finger?

4

Shape

steps, skips, repeats



Before you play music you have never seen, **look first**. Four things: the **key**, the **time**, the **starting note** and the **shape** of the tune.

Half a minute of looking saves a lot of wrong notes.

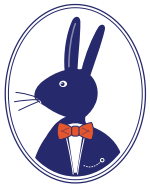
Try it at the piano

1. Open a piece you do not know. Say the four things out loud before you touch a key.

ROOM 8 · STEP 2 OF 2

Reading at sight





Then count one bar and play **slowly**, with a steady beat. Keep your eyes one note **ahead** of your fingers.

If you slip, **keep going**. The beat matters more than one wrong note.

Try it at the piano

1 Play four bars of a new piece without stopping, however slowly. Then do it once more.

ROOM 9 · LISTEN

Ear training

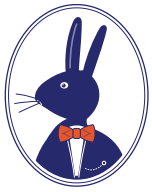
SCAN TO PLAY

1 **Find the home note**

2 **Clap it back**

3 **Sing it back**

4 **Warm-up: which rhythm?**



Listen first, then play. Good ears make good fingers.

Four listening games belong to this level. Each one is in the app: scan the code and play one each day.

Try it at the piano

1 Before you play a note, sing it. Then play it and listen: were you right?